role on 22 October in getting Nehru's nod for the evacuation of Tawang, had the tacit support of the army chief, General Pran Thapar. After the withdrawal to Jang by the evening of 23 October and a further fallback to Nuranang and Se-la the next day, Thapar finally replaced the indisposed Kaul with Lieutenant General Harbaksh Singh. On 25 October, the new corps commander met Palit and the sacked Niranjan Prasad at Se-la Top, where he and the new GOC of 4 Division, Major General Anant Pathania, were briefed and shown around the area. Harbaksh Singh then declared that Se-la Top, despite the arctic windswept conditions, would indeed be the next defensive line.

Sweeping changes were made at all levels: 1 Sikh, 4 Garhwal Rifles and 13 Dogra along with 4 and 2 Sikh LI were brought under command of 62 Infantry Brigade. The IAF was brought into play almost immediately, as Senge on the southern shoulder of Se-la was well suited to receive supplies by air. Pathania was expected to set up his Divisional Tactical Headquarters at Senge Dzong, from where he was to supervise the battle for Se-la while also plugging the two passes on either flank that could bypass Se-la.

The next five days would see morale on Se-la soar despite the difficult conditions that had to be endured by 1 Sikh and 4 Sikh LI. 4 Garhwal Rifles with 3.7-inch guns in support were deployed further down at Nuranang and they were effectively harassing the Chinese who were still on the northern side of the Tawang Chu below Jang. Though contact with the enemy had been broken with the pullback from Jang on 24 October, patrols from 4 Garhwal and 1 Sikh were in active contact with the Chinese.

On 30 October, news that Bijji Kaul had been declared medically fit and was being reinstated as GOC IV Corps spread like wild fire. Harbaksh Singh was to move as GOC XXXIII Corps where he was to replace Umrao Singh.

Kaul returned to Tezpur on 30 October. Strangely, he declined the offer of a briefing by Harbaksh Singh. Kaul accepted the plan that Palit proposed, even though Palit's earlier reservations pertaining to the deployment of troops in such conditions should have become more valid at this stage. Ironically, even Palit's own notes had expressed his reservations: 'At the time, unaccountably, I disregarded that pre-eminent tactical feature [Se-la]. Possibly this was because at that stage, when the Indian Army was still unfamiliar with the techniques of high altitude warfare, I dismissed the